

# The Caregiving System

*When protection helps—  
and when stepping back  
helps children grow*



## We are biologically wired to protect our children.

From the beginning of life, children depend on caregivers for survival. When an infant is frightened, uncomfortable, hungry, hurt, or separated from a caregiver, their attachment system motivates them to seek closeness and protection.

### THE CHILD'S SYSTEM SAYS

“Something doesn't feel safe. Find my person.”

### THE CAREGIVER'S SYSTEM SAYS

“My child needs me. Protect them.”

Caregivers have a complementary system. A child's distress naturally activates a powerful urge to move toward them—to comfort, reassure, protect, fix, and make things better.

Neither response is a weakness. They are deeply rooted human systems that help keep vulnerable children alive.

Children grow—and the way we protect them has to grow, too.

# From protection to capability

A newborn needs a caregiver to do almost everything.

As children mature, however, they gradually develop their own ability to:

- cope with distress • tolerate uncertainty • solve problems • communicate their needs
- recover from disappointment • manage anxiety • navigate conflict • make decisions
- take appropriate risks

Healthy caregiving therefore changes over time.

EARLY CHILDHOOD

“I'll do it for you.”

AS ABILITIES EMERGE

“We'll do it together.”

AS CONFIDENCE GROWS

“You do it. I'll help if you need me.”

INCREASING  
INDEPENDENCE

“You can handle this. I'm still here.”

The goal isn't to make children stop needing their parents.

The goal is for children to gradually **internalize the capacities that their caregivers once provided externally.**

Co-regulation → Self-regulation    Protection → Supported coping

Supported coping → Independent coping

# A powerful paradox

Sometimes the very instinct designed to protect children can unintentionally interfere with their developing independence.

When a child becomes anxious, a parent's caregiving system may immediately say:

**Help them.**

Reassure them.

**Speak for them.**

Don't make them do this.

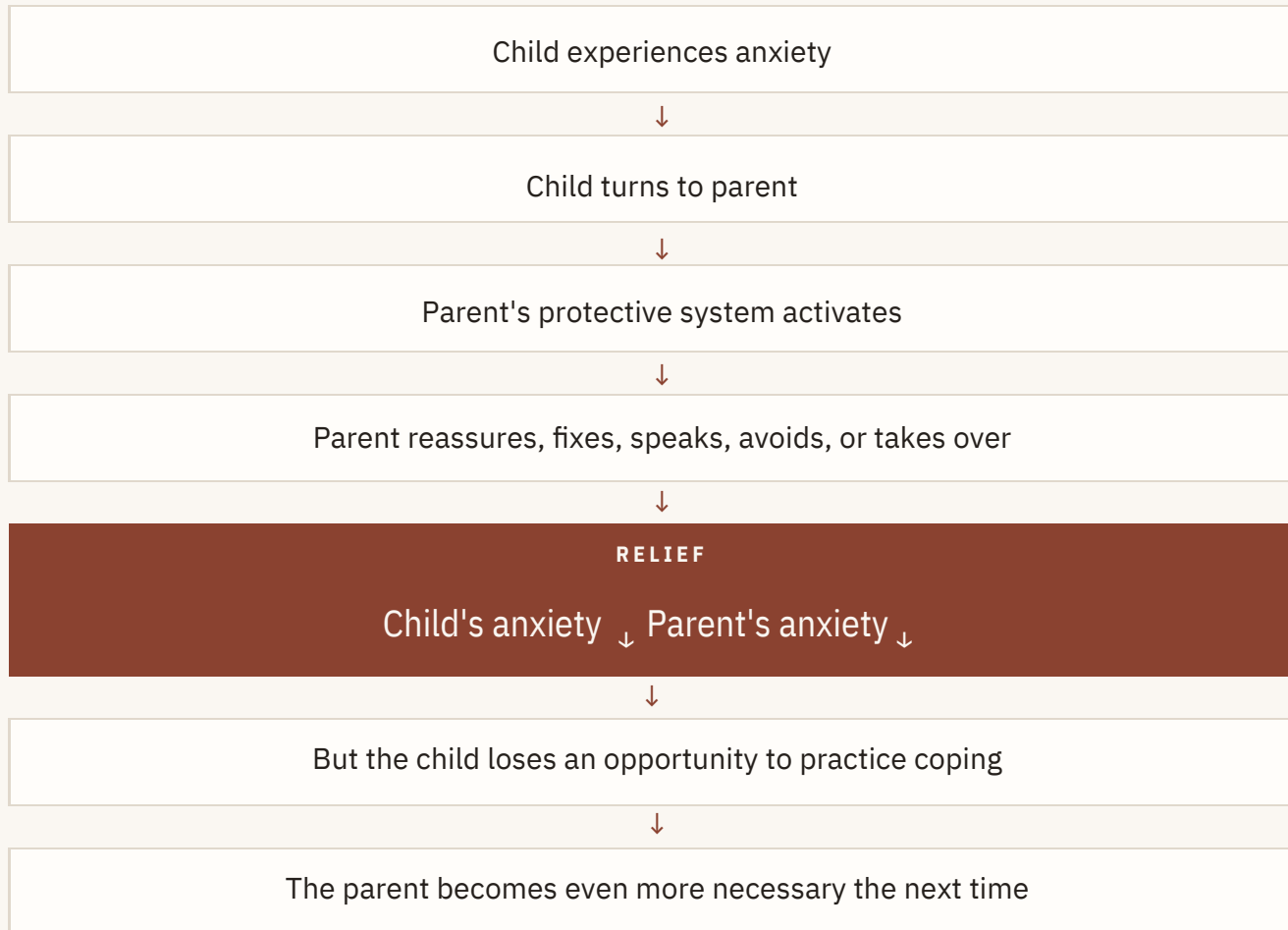
**Fix the problem.**

Don't let them struggle.



Research calls this *family accommodation*: when caregivers alter their own behavior to help a child avoid or reduce anxiety-related distress. Examples can include excessive reassurance, speaking for a child, changing family routines, or helping the child avoid feared situations.

# The relief trap



This doesn't mean the parent **caused** the child's anxiety.

It means that a completely understandable attempt to help can sometimes become part of what keeps anxiety going.

# “But they can do it at school!”

Parents are often understandably confused:

“Their teacher says they do this independently every day.”

“They never act like this at Grandma's house.”

“They'll talk to adults when I'm not there.”

“They can handle it at school—then completely fall apart with me.”

There may be many reasons for differences across settings, including the fact that children often release accumulated emotion in safer environments.

But another important possibility is **parent-supported coping**.

Children may sometimes appear less capable in their parents' presence because they have become accustomed to using their parents as a proxy for coping abilities that are still developing.

When the parent isn't available, the child may discover:

“I guess I have to try.”

And sometimes they succeed. When the parent returns, the familiar external coping system becomes available again:

“Mom can tell them.”

“Dad will fix it.”

“I'll ask again until they reassure me.”

THIS DISCREPANCY CAN ACTUALLY CONTAIN GOOD NEWS

Your child's behavior in other settings may be evidence that they possess more capacity than either of you realizes.

# The circus elephant



Lebowitz and Omer offer a memorable story in *Treating Childhood and Adolescent Anxiety*.

Imagine a young child visiting the circus with his father.

He sees an enormous elephant standing beside a small stake, restrained by a rope that seems far too weak to hold such a powerful animal.

The child wonders:

**“Why doesn't the elephant just walk away?”**

His father explains that when the elephant was very young, it was tied with a similar restraint.

Back then, the elephant really **wasn't strong enough** to escape.

It tried. It failed. Eventually, it stopped trying.

But something changed.

**The elephant grew.**

The animal that once couldn't escape is now vastly more powerful. The restraint didn't become stronger.

**The elephant simply never discovered how much stronger it had become.**

Lebowitz and Omer use the story as a metaphor for children who continue to experience themselves as helpless in situations they have actually become increasingly capable of handling.

# Has your child outgrown the rope?

Children really are helpless when they're little. They really do need us.

But sometimes a child's **abilities develop faster than our picture of their abilities.**

A child who once needed you to speak for them

may now be able to order their own food.

A child who once needed repeated reassurance

may now be able to tolerate not knowing.

A child who once needed help entering school

may now be capable of walking through the door while anxious.

A child who once needed you to resolve friendship problems

may now be capable of attempting a conversation first.

A child who once couldn't tolerate frustration

may now be capable of struggling for five minutes before receiving help.

Sometimes the “rope” isn't the child's ability anymore. It's the belief—held by the child, the parent, or both—that the child still cannot cope.

# The goal is not less connection

## Independence is not the opposite of attachment.

Children still need caregivers who are emotionally available, responsive, warm, and protective. The question is not:

~~“How do I stop helping my child?”~~

### INSTEAD ASK

“How can I help in a way that builds my child's capacity rather than replacing it?”

A useful model from work on childhood anxiety defines supportive parenting as communicating **two messages simultaneously**:

#### 1 – ACCEPTANCE

“I understand that this is genuinely hard for you.”

#### 2 – CONFIDENCE

“And I believe you can handle it.”

## Support ≠ Rescue

### RESCUE SAYS

“You're distressed, so I'll remove the challenge.”

### DISMISSAL SAYS

“There's nothing to be upset about. Just do it.”

### SUPPORT SAYS

“I believe you that this is hard—and I believe in your ability to cope with hard things.”

Connection without overprotection.

Empathy without reinforcing helplessness.

Support without taking over.

# Danger or discomfort?

Before stepping in, ask:

Is my child in danger—or experiencing manageable discomfort?

When there is genuine danger:

**Protect.**

When the situation is developmentally appropriate but difficult:

**Support.**

Sometimes anxiety makes **discomfort feel like danger.**

And sometimes a parent's protective system responds to the child's alarm before there has been time to determine which one it actually is.

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Frustration isn't necessarily danger.

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Uncertainty isn't necessarily danger.

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Embarrassment isn't necessarily danger.

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Making a mistake isn't necessarily danger.

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Trying something difficult isn't necessarily danger.

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Feeling anxious isn't necessarily danger.

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Children cannot discover “I can survive this feeling” if adults consistently ensure they never have to experience the feeling.

# Try one step less

Building independence doesn't require suddenly removing all support. Instead:

Do one step less than you normally would.

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|---------------------------------------|-------------------|
| If you normally <b>do it for them</b> | → do it together. |
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|                                       |                   |
|---------------------------------------|-------------------|
| If you normally <b>do it together</b> | → let them start. |
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|----------------------------------------|---------|
| If you normally <b>answer for them</b> | → wait. |
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|------------------------------------------|------------------------|
| If you normally <b>solve the problem</b> | → ask what they think. |
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| If you normally <b>provide repeated reassurance</b> | → validate once and communicate confidence. |
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| If you normally <b>prevent frustration</b> | → stay nearby while they struggle. |
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| If you normally <b>rescue immediately</b> | → give them a little time to discover what they can do. |
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This is **scaffolding** : providing enough support for the child's current developmental needs while gradually transferring responsibility as competence grows.

# What anxiety actually asks for

DRAWING ON DR. BECKY KENNEDY'S WORK AT GOOD INSIDE

## THE ANXIETY EQUATION

Anxiety = uncertainty + our underestimation of our ability to cope

Most often we try to solve anxiety by reducing the uncertainty — telling our kids that everything will be okay. This tends to increase anxiety, because what helps most is helping a child tap into their own capability.

We can never fully remove uncertainty. Children don't need everything to be okay as much as they need to feel connected to a parent while they are afraid.

## Validate before you reassure

Telling a child all the reasons not to worry can leave them feeling more alone in the feeling, and it signals that we are as afraid of their discomfort as they are.

### INSTEAD OF

"Why are you so worried, it's fine!"

### TRY

"It's ok to feel this way. Tell me what's on your mind, I'll listen."

## Explore the fear with them

Be curious about what feels uncomfortable or scary. The more open a parent is to hearing about fears, the less afraid a child becomes.

## COMMON SIGNS OF ANXIETY IN CHILDREN

- hesitation • shyness • clinginess • tearfulness • protest during separation • tantrums
- fears • avoidance

# Rehearse it, and breathe through it

## Skill rehearsal

Role play lets a child practice tolerating anxiety in advance, which makes it more likely they can tolerate it when the real moment arrives. Practice runs help a child approach the situation rather than avoid it, and approaching is what builds the feeling of capability.

If a child is anxious about a birthday party, set up a pretend one with chairs or stuffed animals and walk through the scenarios together.

### EMOTIONAL VACCINATION

Connecting with a child *before* a big-feeling moment, so they feel more prepared when it comes. Rehearsing the coping skill together is part of the connection.

## Hot cocoa breathing

During anxious moments breathing becomes rapid and shallow, which feeds the anxiety. Slow breathing settles the body down.

### BREATHE IN

Smell the hot cocoa.

### BREATHE OUT

Slowly, so you don't blow the marshmallows off the top.

Do it *with* your child rather than teaching it to them. Practicing together helps a child feel less alone and more willing to try.

Rehearsal and breathing are how “I believe you can handle this” becomes something a child can actually feel in their body.

# Words that steady a child

## I know/ I don't know

Naming both what you know and what you don't know helps a child settle. It gives them something solid to hold without pretending the uncertainty away.

“Here's what I know and here's what I don't know: I know your teacher will be waiting for you and I know there will be many new kids in your class. I don't know exactly how long I will stay before I say goodbye. I also know you can handle this and we'll get through it together.”

## Telling the story

Afterward, walk through how the situation went, what happened next, and how your child coped. It shows them their own resilience in their own recent history.

“I took you to school, you were a little nervous to say goodbye, I knew you'd be safe, you played with friends, and I came back just like I said I would!”

A child learns what to do with a hard feeling by watching someone they trust do it first.

# Show them how you cope

## WHEN THEY CAN'T TAKE IN A SKILL

Often children are not receptive to learning skills when heightened emotionally. To lower defensiveness, tell a story about yourself about how you coped with something hard or scary.

Children are always watching. Seeing that a parent has anxiety and can move through it teaches them that they will be able to as well.

When you are anxious in front of your child, name the feeling as your own, tell them it is not their fault, and keep building your own regulation so you can co-regulate with them in hard moments.

## A STORY SOUNDS LIKE THIS

“When I was little I was really scared of the dark too. I really didn't want to go my room at night. My mom let me hold a picture of her and she told me to tell myself ‘My mom is with me, I'm safe, I can do this’ and that really helps.”

Elaborate on how you coped. The point of the story isn't that the fear went away — it's that the fear was real, and you found a way through it. Naming the sensations you felt, what you tried, and what finally helped normalizes your child's experience and validates that it is genuinely hard.

# Language that builds capability

*Instead of “Don't worry. I'll do it.”*

Try: “I know this feels hard. I think you can try.”

*Instead of “There's nothing to be scared of.”*

Try: “I can see you're scared, and I know you can handle feeling scared.”

*Instead of immediately answering “What if something bad happens?”*

Try: “That's the uncertainty talking. What do you think you can do if something unexpected happens?”

*Instead of “Fine, you don't have to.”*

Try: “I know you don't want to. Let's figure out the smallest step you can take.”

*Instead of “They can't do that.”*

Consider: “They haven't learned to do that independently yet.”

“Yet” leaves room for growth.

## Before you step in, ask:

- 1 Is my child unsafe—or uncomfortable?
- 2 What can my child already do that I may be doing for them?
- 3 Have I seen them demonstrate this ability somewhere else?
- 4 Am I responding to my child's actual capacity—or an earlier version of them?
- 5 Am I helping because my child needs help, or because watching them struggle is difficult for me?
- 6 What is the smallest amount of support necessary?
- 7 What opportunity for mastery might exist if I wait?

AND PERHAPS MOST IMPORTANTLY

“Has my child grown stronger than the rope?”

# The message children need

Healthy parental support communicates:

**“I see your distress.”**

*Your feelings make sense.*

**“I believe in you.”**

*You are more capable than your anxiety tells you.*

**“I am here.”**

*You don't have to face the world alone.*

**“I won't do for you what you are ready to begin doing for yourself.”**

*Because discovering your own strength is part of growing up.*

**The ultimate goal isn't a child who never becomes afraid, distressed, or overwhelmed. It is a child who gradually develops an internal belief:**



**“This is hard. I may feel afraid. And I can cope.”**

*Every successful experience loosens the rope a little more.*

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**CLINICAL FOUNDATION** Grounded in Lebowitz & Omer, *Treating Childhood and Adolescent Anxiety: A Guide for Caregivers* (Wiley, 2013), particularly Chapter 8, “Parental Support and Protection.” Their SPACE model focuses on increasing supportive parental responses while systematically decreasing anxiety-driven family accommodation. A randomized trial of 124 children ages 7–14 found the parent-based SPACE intervention was noninferior to child CBT for anxiety outcomes and produced greater reductions in family accommodation.